implementation a year later, also affirmed the Cold War détente in Berlin and affirmed the vision for cooperation in the walled city.[13]

Concurrently, more artists began making sense of the Wall's shifting and embedded physicality as well as the geopolitical terrain on which the border was situated. Artists aware of continued American military presence in West Germany, discerning the festering pockmarks of past conflicts, and those taking advantage of emergent cultural programs pondered the ways such an insistently violent border could be approached. They turned to conceptual and site-specific projects dealing with its material existence at a time of sublimated violence and border tensions. While the Wall's inner and outer layers were in a state of near-constant repair, continued sublimated terror, and routine bureaucratic watch, artists took the lead in publicly reflecting on its increasingly but loosely standardized conditions. German artist Joseph Beuys served as a catalyst to this emergent rite, suggesting that the Wall be raised five centimeters to correct its aesthetic proportions.[14] Beuys, a practitioner of "social sculpture," an expression of the conceptual art movement that placed the experiential elements of viewing or making art over its material value, continually merged performance and installation to comment on German history and division.[15] His call to tinker with the Wall's height was a provocative gesture dually concerned with the physical and the symbolic adaptations of the border.

Tajiri, too, was among a cohort of international and American artists in West Berlin who took on the question of how to approach and represent the Wall as a blunt geopolitical border and a structure deeply in flux. Such cultural figures aimed to make sense of the Wall by attempting to imaginatively "scale" it to a workable size, not to ignore it or to flee its confines, but to bring it to a form and view amenable to critique. This included scrutiny, of its builders, divided citizens, and allied forces across the Wall, all of whom were responsible for the border's daily enactment, negotiation, and improvisation. As Tajiri approached the Wall to capture its fine details and full materiality, divided Berlin also became a place to weigh his own history and status as a self-exiled American.

As a new guest professor in West Berlin, Tajiri surveyed the Wall with an eye toward its unwieldy structural qualities and an exploration of his own artistic and expatriate identity. This chapter explores how this, in turn, led Tajiri back to considerations of American power and presence by the Berlin Wall. Such an approach drew on the interlinked historical experiences,